Classifying anaemia by MCV

CLASSIFYING ANAEMIA BY MCV (sample notes)

Mean corpuscular volume (MCV) groups anaemias:
- Microcytic (MCV below about 80 fL): iron deficiency, thalassaemia trait, anaemia of chronic disease (often normocytic early), sideroblastic anaemia.
- Normocytic (MCV about 80 to 100 fL): acute blood loss, anaemia of chronic disease, haemolysis, early iron or B12 deficiency, bone marrow failure.
- Macrocytic (MCV above about 100 fL): vitamin B12 or folate deficiency, alcohol, liver disease, myelodysplastic syndromes, certain drugs.

Practical approach
1. Confirm anaemia (haemoglobin below reference range for age and sex).
2. Classify by MCV.
3. Check reticulocyte count to assess marrow response.
4. Investigate the likely cause (iron studies, B12/folate, haemolysis markers).

Study tip: "Little (micro) iron, big (macro) B12 or folate."